

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Leviticus

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Leviticus helped ancient Israel live in relationship with a holy God. But Christ has now come as our High Priest and final sacrifice. He fulfilled many of the worship laws in Leviticus. So why do these laws about priests and animal sacrifices still matter for us?

Leviticus helps us understand that God is holy. God's command for those who know him has not changed: "For I am the LORD your God ... be holy, because I am holy" (Leviticus 11:44–45; 19:2; 1 Peter 1:15–16).

Setting

Leviticus continues the story of God's saving work that began with the promises he made to Abraham (Genesis 12, 15, 17) and with the rescue of the Israelites from slavery in Egypt (Exodus 1–15). The events of Leviticus take place at the foot of Mount Sinai. The Israelites had not yet wandered in the wilderness or entered the land of Canaan, the land God promised to them.

God had already made his covenant (binding agreement) with Israel. He declared that the Israelites would be his "treasured possession ... a kingdom of priests and a holy nation" (Exodus 19:5–6). The people had also received the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:1–17), the plans for the tabernacle (the sacred tent where God met with his people; Exodus 25–27; 30:1–38), and instructions for the priesthood (Exodus 28–29). The tabernacle had been completed and dedicated (Exodus 35–40).

Now, in Leviticus, God spoke to Moses about his holy nature. He gave instructions for worship and for the way Israel should live as his covenant people.

Summary

The laws in Leviticus mainly concern the work and responsibilities of the tribe of Levi, especially the high priest (see Exodus 28; Numbers 3:44–4:49). The book includes God's instructions about the tabernacle, the priesthood, sacrifices, holy days, and ceremonial purity (rules about what made a person clean or unclean for worship).

Three main themes appear throughout Leviticus:

1. God is holy.
2. People must worship a holy God in the right way.
3. Israel was to live as a holy people in relationship with God.

A right relationship with God begins with knowing who God is and understanding his character. But human beings are limited and cannot fully understand God, the eternal One. Even worse, when people depend only on their own ideas, they often begin to worship idols instead of the true God.

In Leviticus, God graciously reveals his holiness in ways his people could understand. He also teaches them how to worship him in an acceptable way. Each sacrifice and holy day taught the Israelites about God and about what he required from them.

God calls Israel to know and love him (see Deuteronomy 6:5; 11:1). As a result, they will also love and serve each other (Leviticus 19:18, 33–34). The rituals and laws in Leviticus taught the Israelites how to live lives of love and service, both as individuals and as a nation.

Author

Some scholars believe that Leviticus was written during Israel's exile in Babylon, around 586–539 BC, long after the time of Moses. However, this view raises important questions. During the exile, Jewish worship was becoming more focused on rabbis and synagogues rather than on the priesthood and the tabernacle. This makes it difficult to explain why a book centered on priests, sacrifices, and tabernacle worship would have been written at that time. This view also does not fully explain Israelite worship before the exile, except for the worship practices described or reflected in the Psalms.

It is likely that Moses wrote Leviticus during Israel's time in the wilderness after the exodus from Egypt. Both Jewish tradition and the early church identified Moses as the author of Leviticus. Moses was raised in the court of the king of Egypt and would have learned reading, writing, and mathematics (see Acts 7:20–22). He was fully capable of writing a book like Leviticus.

The book itself begins and ends by stating that God gave these instructions to Israel through Moses (Leviticus 1:1–2; 27:34). Leviticus often describes how Moses received the Lord's instructions and carried them out (for example, 4:1; 5:14; 6:1, 8, 19, 24; 7:22, 28; 8:1; 8:4–10:20).

The Old Testament often refers to Moses as the author of the Pentateuch, the first five books of the Bible (Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deut; see Joshua 8:31–32; 23:6; 1 Kings 2:3; 2 Kings 14:6; 23:25; 2 Chronicles 23:18; 30:16; Ezra 3:2; 7:6; Nehemiah 8:1; Daniel 9:11–13). The New Testament does the same (Matthew 19:7–8; Luke 2:22; 24:44; John 7:19, 23; Romans

10:5; 1 Corinthians 9:9; Hebrews 10:28). See also Genesis Book Introduction, “Author.”

Meaning and Message

Although Leviticus is set in an ancient culture, its message is still important today. God is holy, and he calls the people he has rescued to be holy as well. God’s holiness and his gracious work of redemption (saving his people) are both the foundation and the reason for his people to live holy lives (Leviticus 11:44–45).

The priests stood between God and the people as mediators (those who helped maintain the relationship) of the covenant (binding agreement). They taught the people what was holy and how holiness should be lived out in the community.

The atoning sacrifices provided a way for the people’s sins to be forgiven and for them to be made right with God. The other sacrifices celebrated the people’s relationship with God through offerings and shared meals.

The nations around Israel often offered sacrifices to try to satisfy their gods and gain their favor. But Israel’s worship was different. The purpose of worship was not to control or influence God. Instead, the sacrifices and ceremonies prepared and purified the people so they could come near to him (Leviticus 11:44–45; 19:2; see 1 Corinthians 3:17; 1 Peter 1:15).

In Leviticus, forgiveness of sin and reconciliation (restored relationship) with God are closely connected to the way people treat one another. The book places strong emphasis on social justice and on responsibilities toward neighbors, the poor, and foreigners living among Israel.

God expected his covenant people to love one another as a reflection of his love. This command is repeated throughout Scripture (see Matthew 22:39; Mark 12:31; Luke 10:27; Romans 13:9; Galatians 5:14; James 2:8).